The Last Nickel

By Jane Shepard

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters (in the form of sock puppets). In the original script, additional actors were used for the puppet roles; however in this cutting, JAMIE and JO are the puppeteers. Portraying multiple characters is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

(SETTING: JAMIE'S BEDROOM, night, lights dim. AT RISE: JAMIE is asleep in bed. JO appears at the doorway)

JO: Jamie. *(No response.)* Woo-hoo. *(Nothing.)* Jamie, wake up. The house is on fire. *(JAMIE sleeps on.)* Sssssst. Jamie, your bladder is full. If you don't wake up now you're gonna wet the bed. *(Makes NOISES: raspberries, farts, etc. then jumps on bed, singing.)* "I'm a little tea pot short & stout." *(JAMIE simply turns over.)* Tsk. *(JO gives up, goes to the door, lingers a moment, EXITS.)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 2: *(looks to see that JO is gone then fills the audience in) The Last Nickel by Jane Shepard (Hears JO returning, so feigns sleep once again.)*

(JO ENTERS with TROMBONE.) "Ode to Jamie." (SHE PLAYS loudly JAMIE jumps, snapping on bedside lamp.)

JAMIE: Alright alright alright, stop it! Jo! *(JO stops.)* It's Tuesday. I have to work tomorrow. I'm not doing this tonight. *(JO toots.)* Jo! *(JO lowers the trombone.)*

JO: But it's cute! Do you think a tuba would be funnier? Just the word: "tuba." Plosives are funny.

JAMIE: I'm not doing this.

JO: "Tuba," tell me you don't think that's funny. Anything with P's or T's. Pee-pee poodles!

JAMIE: God!

JO: Puppy! No poo-poo in the tuba!

JAMIE: We agreed you weren't going to do this anymore.

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JO: You decided, technically that is not an agreement. . . . [besides] I'm lonely.

JAMIE: I know. And I'm sorry. But I am too, kid, everybody's alone, that's the way it is. Except for a few good years here & there, when you get a brief respite, but on the whole you know as well as **I** do, "You are the only person --

BOTH: -- With whom you will live your entire life."

JAMIE: You're a good sister, I love you, go in peace *(JAMIE turns off the light and lays back down. JO sinks down against the wall.)*

JO: *(Quietly)* The planet Jupiter is 40 million miles away. They talk about visiting other planets, but it's *40 million miles.* If we sent someone right now, it wouldn't even *arrive* until 2,038. And for them to get back, it would take until they were 90 years old. If they ever got back at all. *(JAMIE sighs loudly.)* I'm talking quietly. *(JAMIE turns on light and pulls box of CRACKERS from under bed.)* Oh. Hungry?

JAMIE: You're acting like a bratty little sister.

JO: Yep.

JAMIE: I love you very much.

JO: Can I get in bed?

JAMIE: No.

JO: Wish ***I*** had a snack.

JAMIE: Can't help you there.

JO: Nobody loves me, everybody hates me, I'm gonna go eat worms. *(JAMIE pulls a bottle of YOOHOO chocolate drink from under the bed and drinks it off.)* Wish I had a Yoo-Hoo .... *(Funny voice)* "Yoo-Hoo! Where are you?

JAMIE: What do you want, Jo?

JO: Don't get all huffy-serious. If you get all huffy-serious you'll never get back to sleep.

JAMIE: I *am* gonna get back to sleep! Because I've got a damn day tomorrow. I took a sleeping pill, I had a snack, I'm not thirsty, and I deserve to rest! I did *everything* right today! I worked hard, I waited 'till I was tired, and I *was* asleep! Godammit, I have to take care of myself now, Jo! I know this is hard for you. I know you can't rest! But I can't help you. I've tried! I sit up with you, I calm you, I listen, we party, we cry! It makes no difference! I can't resolve this for you.

JO: You're my sister. I'm not trying to take over your life, I'm just having a hard time right now.

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Who am I supposed to turn to?

JAMIE: I don't know. God.

JO: God! God doesn't answer questions on how to deal with death. It's policy... "Um, God, about death?" *(As God)* "Shh, Can't talk about it!" *(Self)* But, God -- God? Hello? Are you listening! *(God)* "What?! I gave you the 10 commandments, what more do you want!" *(Self)* Well, I honor my mother and father & I don't pray to idols, how does this help me with the death thing?-- *(God)* "Look! You're just an individual, I'm omnipotent, it's busy! I don't have time to deal with every little question you have, think about it, you'll figure it out! *(Sits on JAMIE's bed)* Think 'till you're pale and you've got big rings under your eyes. Think 'till you're living on crackers and chocolate drink--

JAMIE: Get off my bed.

JO: If you think about it 'till you're *living* death, and *breathing* death --

JAMIE: Now! *(JO moves off the bed.)*

JO: -- Then maybe you'll get it, white girl.

JAMIE: Up yours. *(JAMIE shuts off the light, throws the crackers across the room, and lays down.)*

JO: I just want to talk --

JAMIE: We talked. You can't deal with it and neither can I. Goodnight. *(JO leave scene, but returns with two hand puppets, she crawls up behind the bed as JAMIE prays)* Thank you, God! *(Tries to settle herself, more genuinely)* Thank you for the quiet. Thank you for this beautiful day. Thank you for helping me to continue on. Please let her get through this, I'm asking you, for my sake and hers, just please let her shut the hell up! In your name I ask this. Um ... Amen.

(She turns over. Silence. Two children's HAND PUPPETS pop up from behind her bed: A MOOSE & a stupid PIG. JO speaks for them both in big cartoony voices, like announcers in a bizarre game show.)

MOOSE: Odd man! She said it first, Tim, ooooodd man!

TIM: *{Snorts.}*

JAMIE: Oh, no ...

MOOSE: It's that time again!

TIM: *{Snorts.}*

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JAMIE: No no no!

MOOSE: What's that ya say, Tim? What time *is* it? liiiit's puppet time!

TIM: *{Squeal!}*

JAMIE: I hate the puppets!

TIM: Time for another nightly sojourn into the land that time forgot! *(PUPPETS cheer)*

JAMIE: We're not doing the puppets! Not tonight!

MOOSE: It's Jamie time! And odd man to that! Tim, do you remember the time Jo was taught to pray in kindergarten? It was the first time she every prayed.

TIM: *{Snorts.}*

MOOSE: And the teacher said, "Students, here is how we pray: 'Now we thank you for this food, amen!'"

JAMIE: I'm not listening to this.

MOOSE: And Jo said it, but she just had to wonder, Tim, why did we say 'odd man' at the end? So she went to ask her big sister! Jamie's almost eight so she'll know! *(JAMIE pushes THEM down.)*

JAMIE: Shut up and stop it, you stupid idiots! *(THEY pop back up.)*

MOOSE: And do you remember what Jamie said, Tim? It's so cute. "Well," says Jamie, "I don't know why we say 'odd man.' Maybe men are just odd!" *(PUPPETS laugh and squeal uproariously. JAMIE tries to grab them)*

JAMIE: It's not funny any more! We didn't know how to pray, so what! *(SHE catches TIM and throws him to the ground.)*

JO: Aw, you killed Tim.

JAMIE: I hate the puppets. *(JAMIE faces the chair away from them)* Lemme know when you're done. *(long pause as JO plays with the Moose Puppet)* I can sit here all night. . . go away.

JO: What will you give me?

JAMIE: Uh! God! What do you want? *(JO smiles and takes the Moose Puppet off her hand and drops it to the floor)*

JO: Got a nickel?

JAMIE: What?

JO: "You always have a nickel ... "

JAMIE: *(Smiling)* Oh man. I can't believe you remember these things.

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JO: *(In voice)* "You always have a nickel ... "

BOTH: " .. If you imagine that you do."

JAMIE: How do you even come up with that? I haven't thought of that in years. *(JO holds out cupped hands.}*

JO: Pick a nickel.

JAMIE: If I do, will you let me go to bed? Okay, okay. *(JAMIE reaches for a nickel.)*

JO: Just one.

JAMIE: "One is all you need." *(SHE picks an imaginary nickel out of JO's hands, holds it up, ready to flip it.)* Heads it's ... "Good Vibrations"!

JO: Tails it's ... "Wipeout"!

JAMIE: *(Stopping)* Not "Wipeout".

JO: Why?

JAMIE: I played it at the hospital.

JO: Really? *(JAMIE nods.)* I didn't know that.

JAMIE: Come on, come on, pick something else.

JO: Ooookay, ladies & gentlemen, tails it's ... "To Sir With Love"! *(JAMIE flips the imaginary coin. As soon as SHE uncovers it, JO shouts.)* "To Sir With Love!" I called it! Now put it in! Put it in, let's go! E-2. "To Sir With Love" is E-2. *(THEY come together at an imaginary JUKEBOX.)*

JAMIE: We never had an E-2.

JO: E-2. *(JAMIE pushes invisible SELECTION BUTTONS. JO launches into lip-synch & dance. The choreography is effortless, executed with the familiarity of hours of childhood repetition. THEY eventually lose themselves in it, laughing & hamming it up. *See reference at the end of this selection)* "The time has come For closing books And long last looks must end!" *(Hands JAMIE imaginary mic.)*

JAMIE: "And as I leave I know that I am Leaving my best friend."

BOTH: "A friend who taught me right from wrong And weak from strong, That's a lot to learn. What can I give you in return? If you wanted the moon I would try to make a start But I Would rather you let me give my heart. To Sir, with love." *(As the SONG ENDS Jaimie wipes tears from her eyes)*

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JAMIE: The song made me sad.

JO: *(Sings softly)* "And as I go I know that I am leaving my best friend ... "

JAMIE: I don't want you to ever leave me. I have fun with you. Even in the middle of the night when you wake me up & I'm crabby, you can still make me feel better than anyone else. Like a person again. And I just ... don't feel it that much these days.

JO: Who put the glue in mom's shoes? *(THEY laugh.)*

JAMIE: Who thought it up?

JO: Who actually did it?

JAMIE: Who stapled dad's shirt sleeves closed?

JO: Who ran away from home and took his charge card?

JO: Who did Nickel in a Jukebox? You could always cheer me up.

JAMIE: Yeah, I could.

JO: That's why you played it?

JAMIE: What?

JO: "Wipeout." At the hospital. Did you sing?

JAMIE: Don't bring me down, okay? You got me feeling good, I thought that was the point.

JO: Is that the point? *(JO holds out her hand.)* Wanna nickel?

JAMIE: No. Ah. Yes, I sang, I thought it would cheer you up.

JO: The whole thing, choreography too?

JAMIE: Not at first. You were in a coma. What could you see?

JO: Coma with my eyes closed?

JAMIE: Coma with your eyes half open, glazed. But then I did.

JO: You did?! The whole act?

JAMIE: I thought you might respond. I sang and danced around the room. Well *limped* around the room, I had this cast on my ankle and this crutch. And the nurse came in and turned the tape off and told me to stop it, it was making the numbers on your blood pressure thing go up. That's all, period, no more.

JO: *You* brought it up. . . I am tired, Jamie.

JAMIE: No! No, you certainly are not! *(JAMIE's turn to bug Jo.)* You're the energetic one, the crazy character of the family! I was the wimp.

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JO: You lived.

JAMIE: Oh, hah! You call this living?! Aach! This is not living! *(Holds out her hand to JO.)* Pick a nickel!

JO: What're you gonna do?

JAMIE: I've been thinking of jumping out the window. *(JO & JAMIE stare, nickel held between them.)* Nothing near so bad as happened to you.

JO: I didn't feel it.

JAMIE: That's not how you looked under the car. I don't wanna talk about it!

JO: Okay. *(JO lifts the nickel.)* It's my last nickel. *(SOUND of NICKEL dropping in slot.)*

JAMIE: No! *(JAMIE lunges to stop her from playing the song Wipeout, but JO clicks the jukebox BUTTONS)* I swear, I'll cut my wrists! *(JAMIE digs madly in the nightstand)* I have a knife! DON'T! *(JO's body starts to seize then grows still) (Jamie picks up the puppets and puts on the following show, with the puppets as the doctor and the nurse. JO hums "Wipeout" in the background. *See reference at the end of this selection)*

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DOCTOR: Do we have a pulse?

NURSE: No pulse.

DOCTOR: Recharge the paddles. What the hell happened, she was stable! Somebody give me a count!

NURSE: Five minutes.

DOCTOR: She's not responding! Is there any next of kin?

NURSE: There's a sister.

DOCTOR: There's no air coming through!

NURSE: Code red. We have code red!

DOCTOR: Oh my God, who stopped the respirator! Jesus Christ, who cut the -- *(JAMIE drops the puppets and instead now has a severed RESPIRATOR TUBE in her hand. JO stops the music . . . . Silence.)*

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JAMIE: ME! ME! I DID IT, OKAY? I'M NOT SORRY AND WE ALL KNOW IT! *(JO's body remains lifeless.)* I cut your respirator and you'd have done the same for me, if you'd seen yourself, with your face all bloated and your brain coming out the back of your head. *(JAMIE gently pushes JO's eyes closed.)* My sister Jo, irreversibly, irrevocably brain dead. When they said you were in a

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vegetative state, I just wanted you to jump up and say, "What, Pennsylvania parsnips?" P-word. Plosives are funny. *(SHE strokes her forehead.)* There wasn't a goddamn doubt in me, the last thing you'd want was to lie there with empty eyes and have mom & dad watch you shrivel up. Jesus! All I had to do was picture you pinned under the car, and cut it. . . . *(JO remains dead.)* When that was the only thing holding you from freedom, it didn't seem like much. I thought it would cut you loose. *(SHE sinks down by the bed, still clutching the cut tube.)* The planet Jupiter is *44 million* miles away. If you sent someone from earth they wouldn't even arrive until 2,038. And for them to get back, it would take until they were 90 years old. If they ever got back at all . . . . *(JAMIE begins to cry)* It's a lonely place, Jo . . . I don't think I can do it anymore . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2017 National Qualifier
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Music and Lyrics for "To Sir, With Love" can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yTapoA5RQyo

Music to "Wipeout" can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p13yZAjhU0M